

Chapter 7: He Knows Too Much

By the fourth day, it stopped feeling like coincidence.

Jenny noticed it first in small ways.

Too small.

Almost easy to ignore.

Almost.

Austin Blackwood always arrived after lunch rush started.

Always ordered the same thing.

Always sat at the same table.

But that wasn't the problem.

The problem was what he noticed.

"Your hand is shaking."

Jenny paused mid-pour.

"It's not."

Austin didn't look up from his tea.

"It is."

"I said it's not."

A beat.

"You worked last night."

Jenny froze.

Bao, passing behind her, slowed down.

Jenny forced a laugh.

"So did half the staff."

"Not until 2 a.m."

Silence.

Jenny stared at him.

"How do you know that?"

Austin finally looked at her.

Calm.

Unbothered.

"I saw the schedule."

"That's confidential."

"It's posted in the kitchen."

Jenny narrowed her eyes.

"You were in the kitchen?"

"Briefly."

"Why?"

A pause.

Then—

"I was looking for you."

That made her stop completely.

The noise of the restaurant didn't matter for a second.

Not the clinking dishes.

Not the conversations.

Just that sentence.

Jenny crossed her arms tightly.

"You don't need to look for me."

"I didn't say I needed to."

"Then don't."

Austin studied her for a moment.

Like she was a problem he hadn't solved yet.

Or didn't want to solve correctly.

Then he said,

"You skipped dinner."

Jenny blinked.

"That's not your business."

"It is if you work like that."

"I'm fine."

"You're not."

Her jaw tightened.

"I eat when I can."

"Instant noodles is not eating."

Jenny's grip on the tray tightened.

"That again?"

"It's a fact."

"You're acting like you're my doctor."

"No."

A pause.

"I'm paying attention."

That sentence landed differently.

Too calm.

Too direct.

Jenny stepped closer to the table.

"Why are you paying attention to me?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

He looked at her like the question itself was complicated.

Then he said,

"I told you."

Jenny narrowed her eyes.

"You said you wanted to see me."

"Yes."

"And now you're watching my schedule, my sleep, and my food habits?"

"I notice things."

"That's not normal."

"For you," he corrected softly.

That irritated her more than she expected.

"So what? You're just observing me like I'm some kind of... project?"

Something flickered in his eyes.

"No."

"Then what is this?"

A beat.

Austin leaned back slightly.

His voice lowered.

"I don't know yet."

That honesty threw her off balance.

Jenny opened her mouth.

Closed it again.

Behind her, Bao whispered,

"Ohhh..."

Jenny shot him a look so sharp he immediately turned away.

Austin didn't look at Bao.

Only at her.

"You're always working," he said.

"That's called survival."

"It's exhausting."

"I don't have a choice."

"You do."

Jenny let out a short laugh.

"You think people like me have choices?"

"Yes."

That single word hit harder than expected.

Jenny frowned.

"You don't understand my life."

"You're right," he said calmly.

"But I'm trying to."

That silence between them grew heavier.

Jenny looked away first.

A mistake.

Because now she noticed something else.

Outside the restaurant window.

A small figure standing across the street.

Watching.

Jenny squinted.

"Who is that?"

Austin turned slightly.

His expression changed instantly.

Not curiosity.

Not amusement.

Something sharper.

Colder.

He stood.

"Stay here."

Jenny frowned.

"What?"

But he was already moving.

Jenny instinctively followed a few steps behind.

"Austin—"

"Stay inside," he repeated.

But she didn't.

She stepped out anyway.

The cold air hit her face.

Across the street, the figure turned.

A woman.

Well-dressed.

Elegant.

Familiar in a way Jenny didn't understand yet.

The woman's eyes were not on Jenny.

They were on Austin.

And the expression she wore...

Was not friendly.

Austin stopped walking.

The distance between them and the woman felt too small.

Too intentional.

Jenny looked between them.

Something shifted in her stomach.

"Who is she?" Jenny asked quietly.

Austin didn't answer immediately.

His jaw tightened slightly.

Then, finally—

"My ex-wife."

The world seemed to pause.

Even the city noise faded.

Jenny stared at him.

Then at the woman.

And for the first time since meeting Austin Blackwood...

Jenny felt something unfamiliar settle in her chest.

Not jealousy.

Not anger.

Something heavier.

Something like trouble.

Because the woman was smiling.

And she looked like she had just found something she wasn't ready to let go of.